relations with the Angolan government, most of them without the intermediation of the Brazilian government.

However, the company's arrival in Angola in 1984 was directly associated with the Brazilian government's actions. At the time, the recognition of Angola's independence by the Brazilian government[6] was important to facilitate the company's operation. This is remembered today by the interviewees as a differentiated trace of Brazil's actions in the country, strengthening the bonds between both countries. Brazil also opened a line of credit (US$1.5 billion) for the construction of a hydroelectric plant in Capanda, Malange.[7] With the end of the civil war (1979–2002), Odebrecht's political and economic power in the country was consolidated.[8] The interviewees emphasised the political relevance of the Capanda project for the legitimation of the new government of the Popular Movement for the Liberation of Angola (MPLA). The work started in 1987 and was only concluded in 2004 with the concession of a new Brazilian line of credit, totalling US$580 million from 2005 to 2007. The political relevance of the project seems to overcome its functionality as many interviewees considered the Capanda project a huge 'white elephant' with little social use.[9]

This project became the main vector of Brazilian expansion in the country. In 2008, the Angolan government announced the construction of the Capanda agro-industrial complex in Malange. The complex has 411 000 acres (of which 279 000 were usable); these are meant to host industry, large agricultural and animal farms and small family farms. Odebrecht took part in building the complex in two forms: through partnerships with the Society for the Development of the Capanda Agro-industrial Complex (Sodepac), and the Angola Bioenergy Company (Biocom). The latter will produce ethanol and electricity and will be located in the agro-industrial complex (with grinding capacity of 2 million tonnes of sugar cane per year).

In relation to accountability, the interviews revealed the lack of transparency regarding public contracts entered into by these companies and the national government. In particular, they unveiled the fragility of the bidding processes for public works. Political-business networks with little transparency are the main forms of doing business and signing contracts in Angola and the key factor considered in official decision-making processes. At the same time, the lack of transparency was also associated with the unreliable quality of the services rendered by Odebrecht. According to one local observer, 'There is a road here – Senador Camara and Samba too – which has been rebuilt for the umpteenth time … it's astonishing.'[10]

In Mozambique, the main mark of Brazil's presence is Vale, which has